

SAFFRON RAGE A protest in Bengaluru against BJP worker Praveen Nettaru's murder

SHAILENDRA BHOJAK

KARNATAKA

Tempers Above Danger Mark

By Ajay Sukumaran

of seven, under the pretext of a compromise talk, but assaulted him grievously. Masood died in a Mangaluru hospital on July 21. All eight were arrested, but the air had become tense.

On July 26, Praveen Nettaru, 32, a BJP worker who ran a broiler chicken stall at Bellare, was waylaid as he was leaving his shop in the evening and hacked to death by suspected motorcycle-borne assailants. The NIA has now taken over the probe, but the murder had an immediate fallout. Several BJP workers across Karnataka announced their resignations on social media, concerned about their safety, and blaming the party for issuing empty promises of tough action. Protest demos were held in Bengaluru and elsewhere.

Two days after Praveen's murder, a copycat killing rocked Surathkal, near Mangaluru. Mohammed Fazil (23), who was chatting with a friend outside a textile store, was ambushed by a group of masked attackers who hacked him to death and escaped in a car—a gruesome incident captured by CCTV cameras. Investigation is still in progress in all cases and antecedents of some arrested persons are being probed. But Dakshina Kannada has a long history of communal polarisation. "With polls approaching, people were fearing such incidents," says Muneer Katipalla, state chief, Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), who hails from Surathkal. Five years ago, the district was caught in a similar spiral of violence, with back-to-back murders in the run-up to a state election. Karnataka has only nine months to go for its next assembly polls.

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The backlash from the cadre, which put the BJP on the defensive, is the novelty this time. A public event on July 28 to mark the first anniversary of Basavaraj Bommai's tenure was cancelled hastily. Forced into some tough posturing, the CM said he would not hesitate to adopt the 'Yogi model', alluding to the Uttar Pradesh regime's hard-fisted policy. Higher education minister C.N. Ashwath Narayan went a step further and spoke of police encounters. N. Ravikumar, BJP state general secretary, downplays the anger. Accusing the previous Congress regime of being soft on radical Islamist groups, he says party workers were exhibiting a natural emotional response. They "have the right to protest", he says, even if it went a bit out of hand.

Ravikumar dismisses suggestions that the protests reflected an undercurrent of disaffection among the BJP's youth workers, saying they had all withdrawn their resignations. But many are openly talking of a caste angle—most youth on the frontlines of the often militant activism by party-linked outfits tend to be from the OBC groups, and it is they who inevitably get killed too. The mostly *savarna* leadership, on the other hand, is seen to preach Hindutva at a safe distance from the streets.

That pitch is only hardening. Both BJP MLAs and prominent Muslims stayed away from a peace meeting on July 30. K.E. Ashraf, president of a federation of Muslim organisations, says the community is dismayed with the discriminatory approach on show. They boycotted the peace meet because the CM visited only Praveen's family even though Masood's family stayed in the same vicinity, he says. "He could have gone there too. That would have sent out a message to people." ■